

Middle East Daily Brief

June 25, 2026

Executive summary

10 stories from 7 outlets (6 perspectives) over the reporting window. Leading the day: Strait of Hormuz traffic doubles and oil falls below \$70 as peace optimism grows.

Top stories

1. **Strait of Hormuz traffic doubles and oil falls below \$70 as peace optimism grows** CNN, Al Jazeera, Arab News, BBC, The National · corroborated by 5 outlets Vessel traffic through the Strait of Hormuz doubled over 24 hours to its highest level since late February as shipowners gained confidence following IMO safety assurances. Crude oil fell below \$70 a barrel, its lowest since before the... <https://www.cnn.com/2026/06/24/world/live-news/iran-war-trump-israel-lebanon>
2. **Israel vows to keep troops in south Lebanon as Jerusalem-Beirut talks resume in Washington** Times of Israel, Associated Press, Jerusalem Post, Reuters, US News · corroborated by 5 outlets Defense Minister Israel Katz said the IDF will not withdraw from its southern Lebanon security zone 'even if there is an American demand,' adding no such demand had been made. The vow came as a fifth round of direct Israel-Lebanon talks... <https://www.timesofisrael.com/katz-vows-no-idf-withdrawal-from-south-lebanon-even-if-theres-an-american-demand/>
3. **Rubio tours Gulf, presses Iran on Hormuz tolls and skips Israel in apparent Netanyahu snub** The National, Arab News, Associated Press, CNN, Times of Israel · corroborated by 5 outlets US Secretary of State Marco Rubio met UAE President Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed in Abu Dhabi to discuss the US-Iran memorandum of understanding, securing free transit through the Strait of Hormuz and Gulf security. Rubio said Iran would not... <https://www.thenationalnews.com/news/gulf/2026/06/24/rubio-uae-gulf-tour-iran-us-deal-strait-of-hormuz/>
4. **Treasury to oversee release of frozen Iranian funds as sides clash over terms** CNBC, Al Jazeera, Iran International, The National · corroborated by 4 outlets Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the department would oversee frozen Iranian funds when released, with a large share earmarked for US food and medicine and initial money likely flowing from Qatar under Treasury supervision. A senior... <https://www.cnbc.com/2026/06/24/us-treasury-will-oversee-frozen-iranian-funds-when-theyre-released-bessent-says.html>
5. **US reopens embassy in Kuwait during Rubio visit, months after Iranian attack** Arab News, Al-Monitor, Asharq Al-Awsat, Associated Press · corroborated by 4 outlets The US Embassy in Kuwait resumed operations during Secretary of State Marco Rubio's visit, months after services were suspended in March when Iranian drones struck US missions following American-Israeli strikes on Iran. The embassy will... <https://www.arabnews.com/node/2648443/middle-east>
6. **UN nuclear chief says Iran inspections will resume; Tehran disputes any new commitment** Al Jazeera, Arab News, BBC, PBS · corroborated by 4 outlets IAEA chief Rafael Grossi said inspections of Iran's nuclear sites will happen, echoing US Vice-President JD Vance's claim that Tehran agreed to readmit inspectors. Iran's foreign ministry countered that it had made

'no new commitments'... <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/6/24/un-nuclear-chief-says-iran-inspections-will-happen-tehran-says-after-deal>

By theme

Israel – Gaza & the Palestinians

- **Demand for tunnel maps and privately held arms tests stalled Gaza talks** – Al Jazeera, Associated Press, PBS, Times of Israel <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/6/23/demand-for-tunnel-maps-and-family-arms-tests-gaza-talks>
- **Settler arson torches Palestinian wheat fields across the West Bank ahead of harvest** – Middle East Monitor, Amnesty International, UN News <https://www.middleeastmonitor.com/20260624-theses-of-the-palestinian-wheat-sheaves-when-a-harvest-turns-to-ash/>
- **Defense Ministry civilian contractor killed in building collapse in Gaza** – Times of Israel, Jerusalem Post <https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog-june-24-2026/>

Iran & the US

- **Strait of Hormuz traffic doubles and oil falls below \$70 as peace optimism grows** – CNN, Al Jazeera, Arab News, BBC, The National <https://www.cnn.com/2026/06/24/world/live-news/iran-war-trump-israel-lebanon>
- **Rubio tours Gulf, presses Iran on Hormuz tolls and skips Israel in apparent Netanyahu snub** – The National, Arab News, Associated Press, CNN, Times of Israel <https://www.thenationalnews.com/news/gulf/2026/06/24/rubio-uae-gulf-tour-iran-us-deal-strait-of-hormuz/>
- **Treasury to oversee release of frozen Iranian funds as sides clash over terms** – CNBC, Al Jazeera, Iran International, The National <https://www.cnbc.com/2026/06/24/us-treasury-will-oversee-frozen-iranian-funds-when-theyre-released-bessent-says.html>
- **US reopens embassy in Kuwait during Rubio visit, months after Iranian attack** – Arab News, Al-Monitor, Asharq Al-Awsat, Associated Press <https://www.arabnews.com/node/2648443/middle-east>
- **UN nuclear chief says Iran inspections will resume; Tehran disputes any new commitment** – Al Jazeera, Arab News, BBC, PBS <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/6/24/un-nuclear-chief-says-iran-inspections-will-happen-tehran-says-after-deal>
- **Iran's Pezeshkian says missile programme is non-negotiable: 'without them we'd be like Gaza'** – Al Jazeera, Arab News, Iran International, The National <https://www.aljazeera.com/amp/news/liveblog-war-live-tehran-to-access-billions-in-frozen-funds>

Israel – politics & society

- **Israel vows to keep troops in south Lebanon as Jerusalem-Beirut talks resume in Washington** – Times of Israel, Associated Press, Jerusalem Post, Reuters, US News <https://www.timesofisrael.com/katz-vows-no-idf-withdrawal-from-south-lebanon-even-if-theres-an-american-demand/>

Perspective balance

Perspective	Stories
Qatari	3
Israeli	2
international	2
Emirati	1
Saudi	1
pro-Palestinian	1

Generated 2026-06-24T23:10+00:00 from 10 deduped stories.